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In addition to this, you can also search for books online and browse through the text printed in them. The service allows you to browse through a book as you would in a book shop or a reference library. Books whose copyrights are in the public domain can be downloaded, the rest can only be viewed online and are not available for download.

Of course Google offers Web and Image Search as well, but we know about that already. Apart from this, you have Google Groups, which is the ideal way to search through the Usenet, which, as we know, is the largest of news and discussion board communities!

News, New Stuff & New Places

Google News works as a news aggregator. You can create a news alert for yourself by specifying the topics that interest you. This would keep you updated on all the new happenings from around the world.

Google culls these news articles from Web sites and newspapers from around the globe. They claim to have 4,500 sources for news. The service also has the news divided into a number of categories making it extremely simple for you to search for relevant articles.

You can of course configure your RSS feed reader to keep you updated with the latest stories from Google News. The latest feature added to the News site is the site customisation tool, using which, you can change the layout to suit your taste and save it. So, if Business or Technology news is your area of interest, you can make sure it appears right on top of the site when you visit it.

Another interesting part of Google is Google Labs. Employees at Google are encouraged to work on projects of their own, and if the company feels that a project is worth a shot then it funds the same. This is where the project enters the Google Lab. At present there are a number of innovative products under development at the Lab. A few "graduates" from the Google Lab have been Desktop Search, News Alerts and Local Search.

Google Maps is a product under development at the Google Labs. This is an effort to map the entire world down to the last mile. The online service is quite accurate and helpful when you need to plan a road trip. You get an option of viewing a satellite image, a normal road map or a hybrid of the two. The controls on the site help you zoom in and out of a particular area.

Though it doesn't provide much detail as far as India is concerned, Google claims that this will be rectified very soon. The service however works best if you have a fast internet connection or else be ready for a very long wait while your maps load.

Personally we preferred the satellite images to the road maps. For an American or British user, this service also offers driving directions. All one has to do is key in the query in the search box.

The Big Boys

Other than search tools, you have Google Tools to play around with. The most productive tool or service in terms of monetary benefit has been Google AdSense. This classifieds-like advertising tool lets a normal Internet user, who has a blog or a Web site,